

**GEORGIA**

Capital city: Tbilisi
Area: 26,911 sq miles (69,700 sq km)
Population: 5,100,000
Official language: Georgian, Abkhazian
Major religions: Christian 83%, Muslim 11%, other 6%
Government: Multiparty democracy
Currency: Lari
Adult literacy rate: 99%
Life expectancy: 73 years
People per doctor: 256
Televisions: 473 per 1,000 people

AZERBAIJAN

Capital city: Baku
Area: 33,436 sq miles (86,600 sq km)
Population: 8,400,000
Official language: Azerbaijani
Major religions: Muslim 87%, Christian 12%, other 1%
Government: Multiparty democracy
Currency: Manat
Adult literacy rate: 97%
Life expectancy: 65 years
People per doctor: 278
Televisions: 254 per 1,000 people

ARMENIA

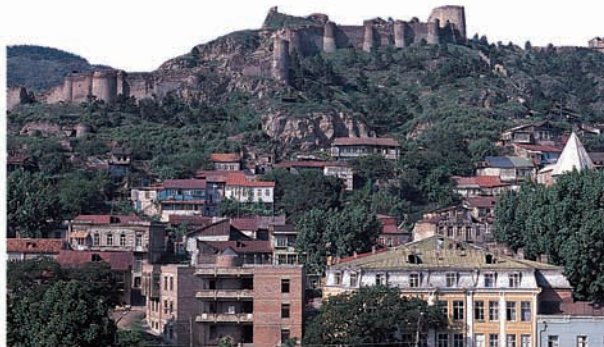
Capital city: Yerevan
Area: 11,506 sq miles (29,800 sq km)
Population: 3,100,000
Official language: Armenian
Major religions: Christian 94%, other 6%
Government: Multiparty democracy
Currency: Dram
Adult literacy rate: 99%
Life expectancy: 75 years
People per doctor: 328
Televisions: 218 per 1,000 people

GEORGIA

GEORGIA IS A LAND OF MOUNTAINS. The Caucasus range forms a barrier with Russia in the north, while snowy peaks overlook the Black Sea in the west. The country's sheltered fertile soil is suited to growing grapes, and Georgia is said to be the birthplace of wine. Its position between the Caspian and Black seas gives Georgia control over the movement of oil and other goods between countries in the region.

TBILISI

The buildings of Georgia's capital rise steeply from the banks of the Kura River. Tbilisi is a uniquely multicultural city, with a synagogue, mosque, Georgian basilica, Armenian church, and a Zoroastrian fire-worshiper's temple within a few minutes walk of each other.

**A LONG LIFE**

Georgia holds a remarkable world record. More people here live to be over 100 years old than anywhere else in the world. Many centenarians continue to lead active lives, some up to the age of 120. Scientists cannot explain it, but they think that the combination of good climate, a healthy, balanced diet, a rural environment, and outdoor work are all part of the secret.

AZERBAIJAN

THIS HOT, DRY COUNTRY lies along the coast of the Caspian Sea. In the 8th century, the Persians named the area Azerbaijan, "the land of flames," when they saw burning natural gas seeping from the ground. The Azerbaijani people are Muslims who conquered the region in the 11th century. Tensions exist over the Nagorno Karabach region, which is populated mainly by Armenians.

**OIL PRODUCTION**

Before oil was discovered in the Gulf states, Azerbaijan supplied half the world's oil output from oil fields near its capital, Baku. Today, villages on floating platforms house workers who drill for oil under the Caspian Sea. A new pipeline opened in 2005, taking oil from Baku via Tbilisi in Georgia to Ceyhan in Turkey on the Mediterranean Sea, promising great wealth for Azerbaijan.

ARMENIA

THIS TINY, MOUNTAINOUS state is the smallest of all the former republics of the USSR. Armenia was the first state in the world to adopt Christianity and is today bordered by three Islamic countries. With no access to the sea, Armenia relies on its neighbors for road and rail links to the outside world, but conflict with Azerbaijan has affected much-needed supplies of raw materials and fuel.

**FARMING**

Farming is the main source of employment in Armenia. Sheep and cattle graze on the high mountain slopes, while fruit trees and cereals are grown lower down.

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